



played by Louis Salou, was inspired by Charles Auguste, Duc de Morny, half brother of Napoleon III.

The world's a stage

From the outset, the movie blurs the line between the stage and real life. Everything is about the theatrical show of life. Even the title of the movie refers to the highest

Rejected by Garance. Baptiste marries Nathalie, played by Maria Casares, an exiled Spanish Republican associated with the Resistance.

balcony in the theater, known as “paradise” (in Britain they call it “the gods”), where the cheapest seats in the house are situated. The Boulevard du Crime itself seems

“**Jealousy** belongs to all if a woman belongs to **no one.**”

Frédéric Lamaître / Children of Paradise

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To be a producer, one must be a gambler, and the greatest French producers were gamblers.

Marcel Carné

”

like a stage, jostled through and caroused on by a vast and rowdy army of colorful figures, courtiers, and lowlifes alike. The movie opens with a theater curtain that parts as the camera glides down a Boulevard du Crime crowded with extras, and enters a carnival display where another curtain labeled “The Naked Truth” opens to reveal Garance bathing in a barrel of water, visible only from the shoulders up, and staring at her reflection in a mirror.

Elusive love

Garance becomes involved with each of her suitors in turn: first with Baptiste, the mime, who saves her from a false charge of theft; then with Frédéric, who steps in confidently after Baptiste realizes that Garance can't return his love; thirdly, with the criminal Lacenaire; and finally, de Montray, who offers Garance protection when she is drawn unwittingly into Lacenaire's crimes.

Garance is briefly intrigued by all four men, bestowing her affection on each of them in her own way, yet she remains utterly elusive, and cannot love them in the way that they dote upon her. In the first half of the story, as each receives some measure of attention from her, the